ETHICS FATIGUE

The Modern Sisyphus in the Age of AI

Jasper Kyle Catapang

Tokyo University of Foreign Studies · Money Forward Japan

April 12, 2026

Sisyphus by Titian, ca. 1549, oil on canvas

I sit at an uncomfortable intersection.

Not one role. Three — each asking a different question about the same technology.

PhD Student

01

Global Studies · TUFS

How AI reshapes language, identity, and power. Who gets represented — and who gets erased.

What does this do to people?

AI Engineer

02

Money Forward, Tokyo

Building NLP and LLM systems in production. I know which corners get cut and why.

How is this actually built?

AI Researcher

03

Ethics & Explainability

Investigating whether AI systems can be trusted, audited, and understood — beyond just accuracy.

Should we, and how do we know?

That tension is what this talk is about.

SISYPHUS.

Condemned to push the boulder uphill.

Forever. Only to watch it roll back down.

THE MODERN SISYPHUS:

The AI ethicist inside a tech company.

Their boulder? Ethics. The hill? Profit, speed, and scale.

The promise was real.

EU AI Act | NIST AI RMF | IEEE 7000 | OECD Principles

Frameworks. Guidelines. Principles. All published with confidence.

> *But high-level guidance without enforceable, end-to-end operational controls is not enough.*

The principles-to-practice gap: named, documented, and still wide open.

FAILURE PROPAGATES.

DATA	TRAIN	DEPLOY	MONITOR
Bias	Amplified harms	Hallucination	Reactive only
Consent violations	Flawed alignment	Misuse & opacity	Underfunded
Data colonialism	Env. cost ignored	Scaled harm	Too late

Ethics boards dissolved. Safety teams overruled. Principles published. Controls skipped.

WHAT GETS SKIPPED HAS A NAME

These aren't hypotheticals.

- **Weapons targeting**

  AI-assisted lethal decisions with no human accountability

- **Hiring & recruitment**

  Biased systems screen out candidates before a human ever looks

- **Predictive policing**

  Racially skewed models decide who gets surveilled before any crime

- **Healthcare triage**

  Flawed risk scores determine who receives care — and who waits

- **Social credit & scoring**

  Automated systems deny loans, housing, and rights with no appeal

- **Mass unemployment**

  Automation deployed faster than safety nets can be built

- **Content moderation**

  Minority languages and voices disproportionately silenced at scale

- **Surveillance & tracking**

  Facial recognition misidentifying and endangering real people

These are the consequences of the boulder rolling back down.

FATIGUE.

ETHICS WASHING

Publish the framework.
Ship the model anyway.
Repeat.

THE RETROFIT TRAP

AI bolted onto pipelines
not built for it.
No hooks. No control.

THE HUMAN COST

Burnout. Cynicism. Exit.
Communities harmed
by what we skipped.

"Principles alone cannot guarantee ethical AI." — Mittelstadt, Nature Machine Intelligence (2019)

THE STAKES

Every new model resets the boulder.

Multimodal and agentic systems expand the ethical surface area.

Autonomous agents act without human oversight at critical moments.

Unresolved ethical debt at scale becomes infrastructure — nearly impossible to undo.

BUT THE GROUND IS SHIFTING.

External pressure is doing what internal advocacy couldn't.

REGULATION

EU AI Act — binding obligations for high-risk systems. Ethics moving from voluntary to enforceable.

ACCOUNTABILITY

Whistleblowers, open letters, and researcher coalitions changing the narrative globally.

GUARDRAILS AS INFRASTRUCTURE.

Not just principles. Enforcement mechanisms embedded into how AI is built.

TECHNICAL GATES

Fairness thresholds, toxicity checks, and drift detection embedded into CI/CD pipelines — blocking deployment, not just flagging it.

ECO ACCOUNTABILITY

Carbon and water budgets as first-class criteria. Environmental impact treated as seriously as accuracy. (Green AI, Strubell et al.)

REGULATORY TEETH

EU AI Act mandates conformity assessments, human oversight, and audit trails for high-risk systems. Non-compliance has real consequences.

COALITION POWER

Cross-border researcher networks, open letters, and whistleblowers. The ethics community pushing together — not in silos.

THE HILL HAS A SUMMIT.

IF YOU BUILD AI — Design ethics in from day one. Ethical debt compounds.

IF YOU WORK IN ETHICS — Build control architectures. Find your coalition. Push together.

IF YOU'RE A CITIZEN — Public pressure moves regulation. Your voice raises the hill.

"Ethics cannot be an afterthought. It must be an organizing principle from day one."

Thank you.

Jasper Kyle Catapang

in linkedin.com/in/jcatapang

@ jasperkylecatapang@gmail.com

W jaspercatapang.github.io

Disclosure

All content, arguments, and ideas in this presentation were written by Jasper Kyle Catapang. Slide design and layout were generated with Claude Sonnet 4.6 (Anthropic). Cover image: Sisyphus by Titian, ca. 1549, oil on canvas.